

When Android Invades the Enterprise...

This article explores the challenges in managing handheld devices based on the Android platform that are being used in an enterprise. It also explains the complexities of creating an enterprise-ready Android platform, which is a must for companies that want to manage their workforce and keep their data secure.



The enterprise mobility trend and its unique benefits have made enterprises open to empowering their employees and customers with one-tap access to business data from any handheld device. New business opportunities are emerging as billions of people rapidly embrace the use of mobile devices. However, the innovation rate in mobile devices, social media software and cloud computing is accelerating faster than the enterprise adaptation rate.

In a report by the comScore MobiLens service, which underlined key trends in the US smartphone industry during the three month period ending June 2013, Google Android is the leading smartphone platform with 52 per cent market share.

There is little doubt that Android has become the dominant platform because of its commercial-friendly licence, hassle-free supply chain commoditisation, robust architecture, together with the open source and easily customisable code base. These benefits have led more and more enterprises to look at Android as a cost-effective mobile platform for corporate-owned devices given to their field force. While empowering the field force results in

high productivity gains, companies have certain concerns regarding regulatory compliance, security, technology, expense, organisational policy, and legacy technology constraints. Addressing all of these concerns is critical for an enterprise and, in turn, has created a high demand for devices powered by an enterprise-ready Android platform.

The need for an enterprise-ready Android platform

As we know, managing devices is inevitable for any enterprise in this era of cyber-crimes and the high incidence of security breaches suffered by enterprises due to lack of proper device management. Enterprises typically manage their employees' devices by leveraging one of the several mobile device management solutions available in the market like BoxTone, MobileIron, Soti, etc. Like other smartphone platforms, Android too provides for some essential device management features built into the platform and exposed to the applications. The mobile device management solutions deploy an on-device agent that takes care of policy management and enforcement by leveraging the built-in device management APIs supported by the mobile platform.